emerging détente between East and West Germany. It also coincided with a critical student-led grassroots activism addressing other political fault lines in West Germany, notably stirred by a backlash to Western militarism in the era of the Vietnam War. Davis also departed for Europe during the formative years of the Black Power movement, within days of one of its watershed moments, the Watts Rebellion of 1965. Davis, who would later become one of the most recognizable and influential intellectual figures of her generation, was twenty-one years old at the time and on a pathway to advanced academic training, thousands of miles from the surging Black Power movement.

Davis was born in 1944 and was raised in the Birmingham neighborhood ignominiously deemed "Dynamite Hill" for the waves of bombings targeting black family homes, among other violent actions carried out by white supremacist vigilantes. Davis's parents were teachers and members of the NAACP, and her mother had worked on the campaign to free the Scottsboro Boys in the 1930s. Davis left Birmingham as a teenager to attend Elizabeth Irwin High School in New York City and, later, Brandeis University in Massachusetts, where she majored in French and worked with her mentor German American philosopher and professor Herbert Marcuse. During her junior year she studied abroad in Paris, where she experienced global manifestations of racism during the Algerian fight for independence.[2] On her way back to Brandeis, she stopped in Frankfurt to attend lectures by the German Jewish intellectual Theodor Adorno. Her German language skills were limited at the time, but she was aided by English and French translations. Her studies in Frankfurt thus allowed Davis to gain a significant foothold into the world of German philosophy and critical theory. During her final year at Brandeis she was awarded a German State Scholarship to return to Frankfurt for graduate school. After graduating, she embarked for West Germany.

Davis went on to study philosophy at the Goethe University in Frankfurt, one of the most highly regarded departments of its time, recognized as a global center of critical engagement. She studied with illustrious professors of the Frankfurt School—including Adorno, Jürgen Habermas, and Oskar Negt, who sought to leverage critical theory as a response to European and global politics in the years of rebuilding after the world's war.

Despite Davis's distance from home, Germany proved to be a site of awakening for her evolving social consciousness. In West Germany, Davis's